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IN BRIEF



M.P. hikes green gram procurement to 60% amid stir

BHOPAL
The Madhya Pradesh government has increased the limit of green gram procurement from 25% to 60% of the total crop of farmers, State Agriculture Minister Aidal Singh Kansana said after a meeting with farmer representatives. » **Page 12**

‘Devise formula for distress sharing of Cauvery water’

CHENNAI
Cauvery Water Regulation Committee chairperson Vineet Gupta on Wednesday asked Tamil Nadu and Karnataka to come up with a distress-sharing formula. » **Page 4**

SC restricts ‘retrospective’ environmental clearances

Top court quashes 2021 Office Memorandum on the matter with prospective effect; it upholds power for ‘amnesty schemes’, but through proper notifications instead of administrative orders

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Wednesday quashed, with prospective effect, a 2021 Office Memorandum (OM) granting *ex post facto* environmental clearances to infrastructure projects, holding that the Union government cannot substantially alter protective environmental checks by issuing mere administrative instructions. “The 2021 OM is an administrative order, and envisages a perpetual regime for grant of environmental clearance to projects undertaken without prior environmental clearance. It substantially alters the nature of enquiry and criteria for grant of environmental clearance under the 2006 notification. It supplants

The 2021 Office Memorandum is an administrative order, and envisages a perpetual regime for grant of environmental clearance to projects undertaken without prior environmental clearance. It substantially alters the nature of enquiry and criteria for grant of environmental clearance under the 2006 notification
SUPREME COURT JUDGMENT

an earlier delegated legislation [2006 notification] through an administrative instruction, which is impermissible in law,” the court noted in an 80-page judgment.

‘No parallel route’
An ‘amnesty’ measure cannot become a permanent, parallel route which circumvents the prior environmental clearance (EC) regime under the 2006

notification of the Environment Ministry. A valid amnesty measure should be used as a rare exception, must be finite in duration and confined to its class, a Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant observed.

The court said the prior EC regime of the 2006 notification, spanning across various sectors such as highways, airports, real estate and township develop-

ments, and mining and resource extraction, was mandatory in nature.

The 2006 notification’s mandate could have only been amended through a subsequent and appropriate amnesty notification for select, deserving projects whose continuation was of “supervening public interest”, Justice Joymalya Bagchi, who authored the judgment, held.

The court barred the Centre from passing administrative orders to grant *ex post facto* clearances in the future. Justice Bagchi added that the present judgment would not, however, stand in the way of the top court granting *ex post facto* clearances in exercise of its plenary powers under Article 142 of the Constitution.

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U.S. fast-tracks Act for 100% tariffs on trade partners of Russia

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan
NEW DELHI

The U.S. Senate has voted to fast-track the passage of a legislation that could see a tariff of 100% being imposed on India for its import of Russian oil.

The Senate on Tuesday exhibited a rare display of bipartisan agreement by voting 86-12 to invoke a cloture motion to advance the ‘Lindsey O. Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026’.

The original version of the Act, introduced in 2025, proposed 500% tariff on those importing Russian oil. However, the Act was revised downwards early this month.

As per Senate documents, the bipartisan Act “is designed to deprive [Russian President] Vladimir Putin of the revenue financing Russia’s war against Ukraine” by limiting political leadership, fi-

Trade troubles

The proposed U.S. sanctions seek to use targeted tariffs to pressure Russian energy purchasers to reduce their dependence on Moscow

■ Under the latest version of the Act, a tariff of ‘**up to 100%**’ would be levied on the top five purchasers of Russian crude oil and natural gas

■ Currently, China accounts for about **47-50%** of Russian crude oil exports, while India accounts for another **36-38%**

nancial institutions, energy sector, and sanctions-evasion networks. The sanctions are to be implemented using “targeted tariffs to pressure the world’s largest purchasers of Russian energy to reduce their dependence on Moscow”.

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U.S. and Iran resume fighting in West Asia

Associated Press
Agence France-Presse
CAIRO/WASHINGTON

Jordan intercepted missiles launched from Iran early on Wednesday, hours after the U.S. military said it knocked down another Iranian barrage launched against American forces in the region, ending a brief pause in fighting between Tehran and Washington.

The U.S. also said it worked with Saudi Arabia to fire on Iran-backed militias in Iraq that have targeted the kingdom in recent days. The militias said at least 20 of their fighters had been killed. Six Iranian advisers were also killed in the strikes, Iraqi militia officials said.

The fighting came after days in which mediators said some progress had been made in negotiations to end the war.

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Cubs’ crusade



Roaring appeal: Children in tiger costumes taking part in an awareness campaign in Bengaluru on Wednesday as part of International Tiger Day. India is home to the world’s largest wild tiger population, accounting for nearly 70% of all wild tigers globally. K. MURALI KUMAR

Eggs to stay on midday meal menu in schools: Bengal CM

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Putting an end to the controversy over the alleged denial of eggs in midday meals for schoolchildren in Kolkata, West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Wednesday said while the International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON) will provide protein-rich midday meals to children, eggs will be provided separately through self-help groups (SHGs).

Pilot project
“From August 1, as a pilot project, *satvik* and protein-rich midday meals will be provided to children by ISKCON in large parts of Kolkata. Along with that, eggs will be provided to children through SHGs so that we can provide pro-



Suwendu Adhikari

tein-rich meals to our future generations,” the Chief Minister said.

When Mr. Adhikari had announced that ISKCON would be providing cooked meals to schools in Kolkata, it raised concerns that eggs would be removed from midday meals.

Members of Opposition parties, including Trinamool Congress chairperson and former Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee, questioned why school-

children were being deprived of eggs, which are a good source of protein.

The move to entrust ISKCON with providing midday meals was also criticised as an attempt by the BJP government to impose vegetarianism in the State.

Allocation hiked
The Chief Minister added on Wednesday that the State government has increased the allocation for midday meals from ₹6.78 to ₹10 per student per day. Mr. Adhikari also distributed grants to 80,375 government and government-aided schools under the Samagra Shiksha scheme at the State Secretariat. He said all vacant teacher posts in schools would be filled soon and about 50,000 new teachers will be appointed.

BS-III vehicles may need some tweaks for E20 fuel, says Centre

Jagriti Chandra
NEW DELHI

Some rubber parts and gaskets in BS-III vehicles may require replacement when using E20 fuel, a blend of 20% ethanol and 80% petrol, the Union government informed Parliament on Tuesday.

“In case of testing done on BS-III vehicles introduced from 1st April, 2005 and manufactured prior to 2016, some rubber parts and gaskets may require replacement, which can be easily managed during routine servicing regime of the vehicle,” Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari said in the Rajya Sabha, citing findings of a study.

Not yet made public
He was responding to a question from the Communist Party of India MP A.A. Rahim on the impact of E20 on vehicle performance, fuel efficiency, engine durability, and maintenance costs. The study is yet to be made public.

The study was carried out by Indian Oil Corporation Limited; the Indian Institute of Petroleum, Dehradun; the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers, and the Automotive Research Association of India.

Other than BS-III vehicles, the study showed there was no need to modify car and two-wheeler engines, the Minister said.

There have been widespread anecdotal complaints of vehicles misfiring or breaking down.

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INBRIEF



Kanwar Yatra begins today; illegal meat shops to be shut

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi on Wednesday ordered the closure of unauthorised meat shops and outlets along Kanwar Yatra routes and near camps ahead of the pilgrimage beginning on Thursday, following a meeting with the Delhi government. An office memorandum issued after a review meeting chaired by Minister Kapil Mishra directed the removal of encroachments, round-the-clock sanitation, fumigation and deployment of mobile dispensaries. A total of 308 camps will be set up across the Capital. According to the police, about 1,600 personnel will be deployed along the yatra routes. Checkpoints will be set up at entry points and additional forces will be deployed to manage crowds and ensure pilgrims’ smooth movement.

City court stays non-bailable warrants against Aishe Ghosh

A Delhi court on Wednesday stayed the operation of the non-bailable warrants issued against Students’ Federation of India (SFI) joint secretary Aishe Ghosh in connection with a 2021 case related to protests and demonstrations at Banga Bhawan. Judicial Magistrate (First Class) Vijayshree Rathore of the Patiala House Courts passed the order directing Ms. Ghosh to appear in person on Thursday, the next date of hearing. According to the case records, the warrants were issued against Ms. Ghosh on December 12, 2024 and again on April 11 this year after she failed to appear before the court during the proceedings. The order comes a day after the SFI accused the Delhi police of a “witch-hunt” against Ms. Ghosh following an alleged attempt to arrest her from the headquarters of the CPI(M) in the Capital.

Students return to Jantar Mantar over ‘police crackdown’

First protest at the site after CJP’s 36-day agitation calls for a halt to police harassment in various States; Dipke seeks action over firing of pellet guns

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Students from various Left organisations held a protest at Jantar Mantar on Wednesday against the “police crackdown” in States such as West Bengal, Bihar, and Assam on protesters who participated in the 36-day stirred by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) in New Delhi.

The protest, the first at Jantar Mantar since the CJP called off its stir on July 25, started at 3 p.m. and continued for around two hours. The call was issued by 13 outfits, including the Students’ Federation of India, All India Students’ Association (AISA), Krantikari Yuva Sangathan, and All India Students’ Federation. AISA national president Neha, who was on hunger strike for 23 days in the CJP-led stir, was also present at the protest.

Students held up placards and posters that read ‘Rise in rage’ and ‘Stop implicating students on false charges’. Some also called for the resignation of Union Home Minister Amit Shah over “police brutality” during the July 20 ‘Chalo Sansad’ march.



The protest by 13 outfits began at 3 p.m. and continued for 2 hours; barricades welded together at Jantar Mantar. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The protesters walked past barricades welded together by the police to create an enclosed space and regulate entry.

‘Not terrorists’
Meanwhile, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke on Wednesday demanded action against those responsible for ordering the use of pellet guns on July 20. Asserting that “students are not terrorists”, Mr. Dipke warned that a fresh agitation on a “much bigger scale” would be launched if “harassment” by police forces continues. “In many States, police are visiting the homes of students and threatening them with ar-

rests,” he told reporters at the Aurangabad airport on his way home.

In a post on X, the CJP accused the Delhi police of issuing takedown notices and registering FIRs to remove social media posts criticising Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

When reached for comment, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations) Vinit Kumar said, “We send notices for content that spreads misinformation, has AI-generated or deepfake content or is misleading in any form. The process is part of our social media monitoring.” (With inputs from PTI)

Ease of doing business, services delivery Bills to be tabled in House

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Two key Bills – the Delhi Ease of Doing Business Bill, 2026 and the Delhi (Right of Citizen to Time Bound and Ease of Delivery of Service) Bill, 2026 – are expected to be tabled in the Assembly during the Monsoon Session scheduled from August 7 to 11, sources said on Wednesday.

During the day, Lieutenant-Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta reviewed the ongoing drive to streamline regulations and minimise compliance burdens in the Capital, which includes the proposed legislation on ease of doing business, a source said. The Bill is expected to be cleared by the Cabinet within a week to allow it to be tabled in the House.

The second Bill, which is set to replace the Delhi (Right of Citizen to Time Bound Delivery of Services) Act, 2011, was approved by the Cabinet earlier this month. It proposes to impose a fine of ₹250 per day, subject to a maximum of ₹5,000, on erring officials if a service is delayed without valid justification.

‘Include Question Hour’
Meanwhile, the Opposition Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) on Wednesday urged Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta to include Question Hour in the upcoming session.



CM Rekha Gupta on Wednesday reviewed the govt.’s ongoing drive to minimise compliance burdens. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

AAP chief whip Sanjeev Jha said the session serves little purpose without it and asked whether the government is trying to avoid the scrutiny of “corruption and irregularities” across departments by preventing members of the House from asking questions.

‘Can extend session’
He requested the Speaker not to allow the House to convene without a Question Hour, adding that the Opposition is willing to support an extension of the session if needed.

“Normally, if a Question Hour is to be held, there is a gap of 15 days so that members can submit questions, the government can prepare replies, and the responses can be placed before the Assembly. If there is going to be no Question Hour, then what is the purpose of this session?” Mr. Jha said.

Man stabbed to death after objecting to molestation

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

A 30-year-old man was stabbed to death after he objected to a group of boys allegedly molesting a woman who was with him inside a park in north-west Delhi’s Ashok Vihar on Wednesday afternoon.

The police have apprehended a minor in connection with the case and efforts are under way to trace the remaining accused, said an officer.

According to Delhi Police, a PCR call reporting the stabbing was received at 3.33 p.m., following which a team reached Khimman Singh Park.

The victim was identified as Sunil, 30, a native of Mainpuri in Uttar Pradesh.

According to the police, the woman, a resident of Jahangirpuri, said three to four unidentified boys approached her and Sunil inside the park.

An altercation broke out after they allegedly tried to molest her.

The police said the woman told them that one of the assailants attacked them with a knife before fleeing.

Sunil sustained multiple stab injuries and was taken to a hospital, where he succumbed during treatment. The woman also sustained injuries, the officer said, adding that a case has been registered and further investigation is under way.

DU opens mid-entry round for UG admission; results of third allocation on August 8

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Delhi University (DU) on Wednesday announced that it would open a mid-entry round for undergraduate (UG) candidates who could not complete the admission process, made errors in subject mapping or whose documents were found to be invalid.

According to a notice issued by the office of the Dean, Admissions, candidates will have the option to apply for the mid-entry round from August 3 to 5 by paying a fee of ₹1,000.

As of Wednesday, 71,342 candidates confirmed their UG admissions against 71,624 seats this year, a university official said, adding that additional seats are allocated every year as many students withdraw from the process midway.

“Allocations under the Children/Widows of Personnel of the Armed Forces, Extra-Curricular Activi-



New students at a session in DU on Tuesday. SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA

ties and Sports quotas will be announced on August 9,” the official said. Results of the third round of seat allocations will be announced on August 8, as per a DU notice. It added that allocations would be based on data available by August 5 and include mid-entry candidates.

Fresh cut-offs, ranks
“The minimum allocation score and ranks in the third round would have no relation to those of the ear-

lier rounds. Candidates allotted seats in this round will have until August 11 to accept them,” it stated.

Meanwhile, student outfits on Wednesday criticised a notice issued by St. Stephen’s College prohibiting students from wearing shorts in classrooms, laboratories and common areas. National Students’ Union of India president Vinod Jakhar said the Constitution guarantees citizens the freedom to decide what to wear, eat and say.

DJB approves Yamuna rejuvenation projects worth ₹4,500 crore

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has approved Yamuna rejuvenation projects worth nearly ₹4,500 crore, including 15 new decentralised sewage treatment plants (DSTPs), expansion of sewer networks, upgradation of existing STPs and sludge management facilities, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Wednesday.

“People often ask when the Yamuna will become clean. The answer lies in building the right infrastructure. When the present government assumed office, the sewage treatment capacity stood at only 749 million gallons per day (MGD), leaving a substantial treatment gap. Now, we plan to increase it to 1,041 MGD,” he said.

“Following these approvals, Delhi will have 28 DSTPs under implementation, comprising 13 approved earlier and 15 new-

The govt. also cleared a project to revive and restore the Wazirabad pondage area in order to enhance raw water storage capacity

ly awarded projects,” the Minister added.

Mr. Singh also said the government has approved a project to revive and restore the Wazirabad pondage area to enhance raw water storage.

“This would increase the holding capacity of the pond area from one day to two to three days. The government will also instal 250 water ATMs at an estimated cost of ₹58 crore,” he added.

In July 2025, Union Home Minister Amit Shah had chaired a meeting on the rejuvenation of the Yamuna and directed officials of the Delhi government to nearly double the city’s sewage treatment capacity to 1,500 MGD by 2028.

Trainee IPS officer held for ‘harassment’

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

The Hyderabad City Police’s Women’s Safety Wing arrested trainee IPS officer Uday Krishna Reddy late on Tuesday in connection with a sexual harassment case filed based on a complaint by a fellow probationary officer at the Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel National Police Academy.

Vigilance books former T.N. Minister, raids 41 locations

DVAC alleges large-scale irregularities in the award of bar and transport tenders by favouring select bidders; at least 284 bars shown as closed continued to operate without licence renewal

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) has alleged large-scale irregularities in the functioning of the Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (TASMAC), including manipulation of bar and transport tenders, cartelisation, revenue loss, and corruption involving former DMK Minister and sitting MLA V. Senthilbalaji, senior officials, private individuals, and liquor companies between 2021 and 2025.

The agency registered a corruption case against seven accused persons, including Mr. Senthilbalaji; former TASMAC Managing Director S. Visakan; a close



The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau officials conducting raids at multiple locations in Karur on Wednesday. ANI

associate of the former Minister, Rathesh Raj Shanmugavel, and others. Investigators conducted simultaneous searches on the premises of the suspects at 41 locations across the State since early on Wednesday. The ancestral home of the former Minister was searched at Rameswarapatti in Karur.

The allegation is that TASMAC officials, at the behest of Mr. Senthilbalaji and his associates, violated tender norms while awarding licences for bars in Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Erode, Namakkal, Karur and the Nilgiris by favouring select bidders.

As many as 284 bars shown as closed continued

to operate without licence renewal, causing a revenue loss of over ₹32.81 crore in three districts - Coimbatore North, Coimbatore South and Nilgiris - during 2022-23.

The DVAC alleged irregularities in transport contracts for TASMAC depots, claiming officials misused earnest money deposit-demand drafts submitted by one bidder to award contracts to other transporters. It also alleged that organised syndicates controlled bar licences through proxy operators and political influence. The agency claimed certain distillery and bottle supply firms generated funds through inflated invoices to pay kickbacks for securing liquor supply orders.

States told to deploy drones to monitor stubble burning

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Commission for Air Quality Management in National Capital Region and adjoining areas has urged the governments of Delhi, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Punjab to adopt drone surveillance for effective monitoring of stubble burning, an official said on Wednesday.

“The commission emphasised that UAVs/ drones offer a reliable and effective solution for monitoring stubble burning incidents by providing rapid deployment, high-resolution, real-time imaging and flexible flight patterns that complement satellite imagery and ground inspections,” said the official. Drones can accurately detect active fire locations, identify smoke plumes,



Stubble being burnt in a field in Punjab. FILE PHOTO

map affected agricultural fields and generate time-stamped evidence for prompt enforcement action.

The governments of Delhi and four adjoining States have been asked to ensure that the monitoring area covers paddy cultivation areas, with special emphasis on identified hotspot villages and fire-prone locations.

Mohandas booked for remarks on ‘shooting’ protesters

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Thiruvananthapuram City Cyber police have registered a case against Hindutva ideologue T.G. Mohandas over a recent YouTube video in which he said he “would have shot” the protesters at Jantar Mantar, Delhi, if he were in control.

The case has been filed under Sections 192 and 353 (1)(b) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), Section 66 of the Information Technology Act and Section 120(o) of the Kerala Police Act, related to provocation with intent to cause a riot, publication of statements likely to create fear or alarm and disturb public tranquillity and other offences.

Mr. Mohandas, a former head of the BJP’s Kerala intellectual cell, spoke at length about how he would have tackled the student protests against the NEET exam irregularities. “I will impose a curfew in about a four square kilometre area around Jantar Mantar. Then I would announce thrice for the crowd to disperse. After that, I will shoot,” he said.

In another video, he said secular women who take part in protests “enjoy being gangraped.”

Was misquoted, says Satheesan on sexist remark allegation

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Kerala Chief Minister V.D. Satheesan on Wednesday rejected the charge that he had made a sexist remark in connection with his ad-

vice to mothers about sharing traditional or unique cooking recipes.

He took the stand that he was misquoted as exclusively referring to daughters-in-law.

He said he had, in fact,

asked mothers to share such recipes with “their children and the person who comes as their son’s wife”.

Mr. Satheesan asked how can “children” be construed as daughters alone.

Decide on menstrual leave for women bus conductors, says HC

The Hindu Bureau
KOCHI

The Kerala High Court has ordered that the State government should decide on the demand for paid menstrual leave by women

conductors of the Kerala State Road Transport Corporation within three months.

The court held that the State may consider introducing an appropriate policy providing menstrual

leave to women conductors, subject to safeguards. It opined that a limited provision for menstrual leave would promote employee welfare, enhance productivity, and foster a more inclusive workplace.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi would lay the foundation stone for two sugar mills at Sakri in Madhubani and Raiyamb in Darbhanga district on November 20 this year, Bihar's Sugarcane Industries Minister Sanjay Kumar said on Wednesday. "The State government has set a target of establishing 25 sugar mills," he said at press conference in Patna. The Bihar government is committed to fulfil its resolve to open sugar mills in the State that would not only create employment opportunities but also increase farmers' income, the Minister added.

The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday dismissed a petition filed by Maulana Ali Jauhar Trust at Rampur on the notices for demolition of its university buildings, noting that an interim stay has been ordered. When the matter was taken up before the court, it was informed on behalf of the petitioner that in an appeal filed before the Commissioner, Moradabad, the appellate authority has passed an interim order staying the demolition of university buildings. Taking note of the interim order, the Bench dismissed the petition, saying it need not intervene at this stage. The Rampur Development Authority has directed the university to demolish 38 of its 40 buildings, alleging that they had been constructed illegally. PTI



The scourge beneath HYDRAA's excesses

swathi.v@thehindu.co.in

Ten years and 7 PMs later, did Brexit make a difference?

Brexit's balance sheet

The chart displays the UK trade balance with the EU from 2012 to 2025. The blue line represents the Non-EU trade surplus, and the red line represents the EU trade deficit. Key events marked include the Brexit vote (2016), U.K. leaves EU (2020), and U.K.-EU TCA (2021). The EU trade deficit reaches a low of approximately -1 lakh in 2023.

Year	Non-EU trade surplus (₹ lakh)	EU trade deficit (₹ lakh)
2012	20,000	-35,000
2016	35,000	-75,000
2020	65,000	-45,000
2021	40,000	-40,000
2023	75,000	-1,00,000
2025	50,000	-90,000

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Number of jobs to be cut by BMW by end 2027

8,000 BMW is to offer almost half its German staff voluntary redundancy in a bid to cut 8,000 jobs by the end of 2027, a source said. About 40,000 of BMW's roughly 85,000 permanent employees would receive the offers from October. AFP

Population of Japanese residents in Japan as of January 1

119.74 million. The number of Japanese people living in the country has fallen below 120 million for the first time in 42 years, government data showed on Wednesday, as the nation confronts a low birth rate and an aging society. AFP

Death toll in quake rubble in southwestern Japan

18 Soldiers and emergency workers combed through a badly damaged shopping mall and collapsed houses looking for trapped survivors on Wednesday. The earthquake that hit a day earlier in the Kumamoto area on the southern main island of Kyushu also left at least 62 people injured. PTI

Water ATMs to be installed by the Delhi government

250 The Delhi government plans to install 250 water ATMs for ₹58 crore across the national capital, Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said on Wednesday. "We have approved the project; initially we will start with government schools," Mr. Singh said. PTI

Percentage increase in Nepal's tiger numbers in past four years

20 in per cent. Nepal's tiger population has risen by roughly 20% in the past four years to an estimated 429, officials said on Wednesday, a conservation milestone despite challenges from human-wildlife conflict. AFP
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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Behind China’s AI gift, a constraint

China’s embrace of open-weight AI models is driven as much by compute constraints as by a bid to project itself as a responsible global AI power; until it overcomes chip and inference bottlenecks, Beijing is likely to keep sharing its models with the world

WORLD INSIGHT

Amit Kumar

At the ninth World AI Conference in Shanghai this month, Chinese President Xi Jinping addressed the gathering for the first time in nine years. It is indicative of the priority that AI occupies for the leadership. At the conference, Mr. Xi pitched Chinese AI models as a global public good. The contrast was clear as day. America is selling closed-source, proprietary models while China is offering open-weight models to the world. This distinction is not merely technical, but equally political.

Unlike Anthropic, OpenAI, and Google, which host their frontier models on their respective servers and offer services via an application programming interface (API), Chinese labs such as DeepSeek, Qwen, and Moonshot also release their weights for anyone to download. Unlike American models, these can be customised, modified, and even further trained. There is no subscription to cancel or terms of service. The maker cannot revoke or restrict access. So long as one can manage the requisite compute to host the model, even Papua New Guinea or Senegal can run it locally on their servers. And most importantly, the data never leaves the border.

AI diplomacy

However, one may wonder what explains China’s benevolence. Well, to begin with, the objective is to project China as a responsible AI player in the comity of nations. Unlike the Americans, who he alleged to have overstretched the concept of national security to AI, and thereby adopted an exclusionary approach, China is committed to sharing the benefits and fruits of AI. Mr. Xi’s framing was indicative in this regard. He described AI as “humanity’s collective wisdom,” a “historic opportunity” to “bridge the AI and digital divides,” and something that



GETTY IMAGES

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> “should not be a solo performance by a single country but a symphony of international cooperation.” The underlying message, aimed at Washington, projected Beijing as the open and cooperative alternative to the U.S.’s AI models.

But there is a limiting factor at play too that explains Beijing’s benevolence – its compute constraint, both for training and inference.

Since 2022, the U.S. administration, in concert with its allies, has imposed a series of export restrictions on China, limiting its ability to both mass-import and mass-manufacture high-end chips.

The compute constraint

To understand this constraint, one must separate two very different tasks – training a model and serving it. Training is a one-time cost. A lab assembles a cluster of chips, runs it for a few months and comes up with a finished model. The fleet required is numerically small. For instance, GPT-4 was trained on an estimated 25,000 Nvidia chips, and Meta trained its Llama 3.1 on -16,400 chips. DeepSeek, on the other hand, trained its acclaimed V3 model on -2,000 export-compliant H800s. A frontier

model, in other words, needs chips in the thousands, and it needs them only once.

Serving that model to the public, however, is an altogether different proposition. Inference scales with the user base and requires continuous expansion as it must answer hundreds of millions of user queries. OpenAI crossed a million GPUs in 2025, and Meta targeted the equivalent of 1.3 million by the end of 2025. Thus, for any model with a mass consumer base, the serving fleet dwarfs the training fleet, often by ten to a hundred times.

In other words, the distinction is that of a stockpile and a flow. To train a model, a lab can accumulate ten or twenty thousand chips through smuggling, stockpiling, and modest domestic production. This is precisely why the export controls could not prevent China from reaching parity at the model level. Inference, however, cannot be solved this way. The export controls mean that the most advanced chips remain out of bounds for Chinese firms. Additionally, the concessions the U.S. has offered exist largely on paper. Around 10 Chinese firms were cleared in principle to buy up to 75,000 H200 chips each, but not a single unit had been delivered by mid-2026, as

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCf84MmQ9>

sales remained stalled and Beijing itself directed firms towards domestic alternatives.

China can attempt to bridge the shortfall through domestic production, but even here, restrictions on export of EUVs continue to prove a handicap. SMIC’s 5nm line in China runs at roughly 20% yield without EUV tools, far short of commercial viability. This severely restricts the ability of Chinese labs to offer services via API alone. DeepSeek’s decision to freeze new registrations in January 2025 was influenced by a surge in traffic it could not serve, alongside a reported ‘large-scale malicious attack’.

Openness by necessity

Furthermore, given that Chinese models are nearly as good as the U.S.’s frontier models, their popularity is increasing. Data show that the Chinese models’ share of U.S. firms’ AI usage has hit a record 60% on OpenRouter – a marketplace for routing queries to various models based on requests.

American firms are preferring Chinese models as they provide comparable services at a fraction of the cost. But this success comes with a rider – the need for enormous compute. The solution thus is to simply outsource compute via open-weight models. Hence, China’s open-weight offering to the world is largely a product of its structural constraint. It can build models that rival the U.S. but cannot serve them at scale.

But Beijing cannot ignore the urge to securitise and restrain access for too long. Sooner or later, it will face that choice. Indeed, Beijing is already reported to be weighing restrictions on overseas access to its most capable models.

One can expect China’s frontier models to move towards proprietary models, while trailing models remaining open-weight. But so long as China cannot overcome the larger constraint, it is likely to continue fielding open-weight models. And China’s constraint is the world’s gain. (Amit Kumar is a Staff Research Analyst at Takshashila Institution)

THE GIST

China’s open-weight AI models can be downloaded, customised and deployed on local servers, allowing countries to retain control over their data without relying on proprietary, API-based services.

Even as Beijing promotes open-weight AI as a global public good, it is already weighing restrictions on overseas access to its most capable frontier models, signalling that this openness may not be permanent.

The IACS and the making of modern Indian science

Indian Association for the Cultivation of Science fulfilled Mahendralal Sircar’s vision of scientific self-reliance

Shekhar Mande

The late eighteenth and nineteenth centuries marked a period of profound intellectual and cultural awakening across India, with Bengal emerging as its prominent centre. Although similar currents of intellectual, social, and cultural reform were taking shape in several other parts of the country, the scale, diversity, and enduring influence of this awakening found their fullest expression in Bengal.

What is now widely known as the Bengal Renaissance not only transformed Bengal but also profoundly influenced the intellectual, social, and cultural evolution of modern India. The movement fostered remarkable advances across a broad spectrum of disciplines, ranging from philosophy, spirituality, literature, and the arts to education, social reform, and the natural sciences. It produced an extraordinary generation of philosophers, reformers, educators, scientists, writers,

and artists whose collective vision and achievements laid many intellectual and institutional foundations of modern India.

A vision for scientific self-reliance

One of the most influential figures of this remarkable period was Mahendralal Sircar (1833-1904). Deeply concerned that the colonial administration had failed to provide adequate opportunities for Indians to pursue education and research in the natural sciences, Sircar articulated a bold vision for scientific self-reliance.

In 1869, in an article published in the *Calcutta Journal of Medicine*, he proposed the establishment of the Indian Association for the Cultivation of Science (IACS), arguing that scientific education was indispensable for India’s intellectual and societal progress. As he wrote: “The best method, and under the present circumstances, the only method, that we can conceive of, by which the people of India can be essentially improved, by which the Hindu mind can be developed to its full proportions, is as we have seen

above, by the cultivation of the Physical Sciences”. Three years later, while addressing a meeting of the Bethune Society at the Medical College Theatre in Calcutta in 1872, Sircar lamented the lack of institutional support for scientific research in India under colonial rule: “I must say, though I say with deep regret, that our Government has hitherto afforded no opportunity, nor offered any encouragement to the pursuit of science by the native of this country”.

These statements reveal Sircar’s remarkable foresight. At a time when scientific research in India received little official encouragement, he envisioned an institution that would enable Indians to pursue scientific inquiry and contribute to the advancement of knowledge. That vision culminated in the establishment of the IACS on July 29, 1876, as the country’s first national institution dedicated to scientific research by Indians. Today, as we celebrate its 150th anniversary, we honour not merely the founding of an institution but the birth of a scientific

movement that transformed the landscape of Indian science.

Among the most celebrated scientists associated with the IACS was C.V. Raman, whose pioneering work transformed modern physics. Shortly after joining the Accountant General’s Office in Calcutta in 1907, Raman noticed a “strange-looking board” bearing the name ‘Indian Association for the Cultivation of Science’. Intrigued, he made enquiries about the institution and was introduced to Amrit Lal Sircar, the son of the Association’s founder. Recognising Raman’s enthusiasm for scientific research, Amrit extended an open invitation to use the Association’s laboratories for his experiments outside office hours.

For nearly a decade, Raman followed a remarkable routine. He spent the early mornings and evenings at the IACS laboratory while serving as a government officer during the day. This extraordinary dedication continued until 1917, when he resigned from the Finance Department to accept the Palit Professorship of Physics at the University of Calcutta. Even thereafter, IACS remained the principal venue for his experimental investigations.

It was in the laboratories of IACS that Raman made his most celebrated discovery, the Raman effect, which he announced to the world on February 28, 1928. This landmark discovery earned him the Nobel Prize in physics in 1930, making him the first Asian scientist to win this prize in the sciences. In many ways, Raman’s achievement represented the

fulfilment of Sircar’s vision: that an institution founded and nurtured by Indians for the cultivation of science could produce discoveries of the highest international significance.

A legacy that endures

The founding of the IACS also marked a defining moment in the renaissance of science in India. More than the establishment of a scientific institution, it embodied the aspiration that Indians should not merely learn science but actively create it. Over the past century and a half, IACS has nurtured generations of exceptional scientists, provided a vibrant institutional framework for the pursuit of scientific inquiry, and made contributions of enduring significance to the advancement of science worldwide.

As we commemorate this historic milestone, we pay our deepest tribute to the vision and foresight of Mahendralal Sircar, whose unwavering belief in the transformative power of science made the institution possible. We also celebrate the extraordinary legacy of the IACS itself, a legacy of intellectual curiosity, scientific excellence, and national service that continues to inspire generations of researchers. May that spirit continue to guide the Institute, advancing the frontiers of knowledge and contributing to the scientific and technological progress of India and the world. (Shekhar C. Mande is president, Indian National Science Academy, and national president, Vijnana Bharati)

IN THE LIMELIGHT

Bollywood’s politics of silence, caution and calculated dissent

While some of Bollywood’s biggest stars have chosen caution or silence, others have continued to speak out despite boycotts, trolling and professional setbacks; together, they show an industry balancing conviction with the pressures of political polarisation

Sudhish Kamath

When Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan finally caved in to the protests and resigned, protestors around the country were quick to appropriate Salman Khan’s ‘It’s done bro’ as the defining meme of the moment.

Salman Khan’s first message praised the students, called the paper leak “a very serious issue”, described their agitation as “the right way to go about it” and urged that it not be “hijacked politically”. Less than 24 hours later, after Prime Minister Narendra Modi had responded, he expressed confidence that the government would take strict action and asked the students to return home with an appeal to activist Sonam Wangchuk, 25 days into his fast: “Sonam, it’s done, bro... If you want, will send you food from home.”

Both posts came under fire – from both sides.

Superstar Salman Khan’s posts on the recent student protests perfectly capture Bollywood’s swinging tightrope walk. Silence is seen as complicity and middle-ground fence-sitting as rage unfolds on the streets and outrage on our feeds.

Yet the story of Bollywood’s political engagement over the last decade and a half is far more complicated than the accusation that it has been silent.

Take Amitabh Bachchan. During the Nirbhaya protests in 2012, Bachchan tweeted that he was “pained and horrified” to see peaceful protesters being met with tear gas and water cannons. Last week, as students once again took to the streets, Bachchan’s public timeline was occupied instead by cryptic Hindi aphorisms. He later clarified that they were not about him (or his hospitalisation and surgery) but were inspired by Argentina’s loss in the World Cup, after they went viral amid speculation that he was expressing support for the movement.

Aamir Khan’s remarks on intolerance in 2015 triggered years of boycotts, political attacks and eventually cost him the Incredible India campaign. By 2020, the actor deleted his social media accounts.

Shah Rukh Khan rarely comments directly on politics anymore, though he did ask India to “be democratic” as part of his New Year message before the pandemic. He leaned more towards it in *Jawan*, with an appeal asking citizens to vote thoughtfully. Around the same time, the arrest and eventual exoneration of his son Aryan Khan turned the actor into the centre of one of India’s most polarising media trials – which the younger Khan lampooned in his Netflix show *The Ba***ds of Bollywood*.

Salman Khan has chosen another route – speaking rarely, carefully. During the farmers’ protest, struggling for adjectives, he said: “The right thing should be done, the noble thing should be done, the correct thing should be done...”

Cozying up to Modi

During the 2019 elections, Akshay Kumar’s interview with Prime Minister Modi – remembered as much for its conversation about mangoes – became symbolic of Bollywood’s changing relationship with the establishment. His meetings with Uttar Pradesh Chief



Actor Shabana Azmi kisses the hand of the fasting student activist Neha Bora at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, on July 19. REUTERS

Minister Yogi Adityanath over the proposed Noida Film City only reinforced that perception, even as questions over his Canadian citizenship complicated his image as one of Hindi cinema’s loudest on-screen nationalists.

In 2019, an entire delegation of Bollywood’s biggest names – Karan Johar, Ranbir Kapoor, Ranveer Singh, Alia Bhatt, Rajkummar Rao, Ayushmann Khurrana, Ekta Kapoor, Vicky Kaushal, Rohit Shetty and Imtiaz Ali and several others – posed with Prime Minister Modi in photographs that came to symbolise the industry’s growing proximity to political power.

Politics, in turn, borrowed freely from cinema. *Uri*’s “How’s the Josh?” became an election slogan. More recently, Modi even invoked *Dhurandhar* in a speech to attack those who didn’t like the film.

After watching *Dhurandhar*, Hrithik Roshan posted on Instagram that he “may disagree with the politics of it” but admired its storytelling and craftsmanship. When he shared his appreciation on X, the political disclaimer disappeared. Yet to paint Bollywood as uniformly timid would ignore another, equally consistent tradition.

There are a handful of filmmakers who have consistently been political – Anurag Kashyap, Hansal Mehta, Anubhav Sinha, Vishal Bharadwaj, Sudhir Mishra and, more recently, Honey Trehan, whose film *Satluj*, previously called Punjab 95, was taken off Zee5 three days into release.

Women lead the charge

Deepika Padukone visited JNU in 2020 and simply stood with the protesting

students between the promotions of Chhaapaak. The viral photo was followed by calls to boycott the film.

Long-time activist Shabana Azmi kissed the hand of a fasting student and suffered an asthma attack caused by tear gas used during the *Sansad Chalo* march.

Swara Bhaskar has continued speaking despite sustained online abuse, admitting it cost her acting opportunities.

Richa Chadha has repeatedly defended dissent and free speech and continues to tweet asking people to “come together.” Both these actresses were trolled by the right-wing ecosystem for marrying Muslim men.

Huma Qureshi, accompanied by her brother Saqib Saleem, turned up at the Delhi protests to support the students.

There are many more who aren’t afraid to speak their minds including Taapsee Pannu, Sonakshi Sinha, Gul Panag, Ayesha Khan and Lekha Washington who showed up with actor Imran Khan.

Youth icons join in

Imran Khan at the Mumbai student demonstrations, when asked about “apolitical actors,” said, “If you can’t stand by your own opinions, if you can’t pour your heart into your art, your art has no value.”

Avinash Tiwary used Instagram to urge followers to “make this the biggest protest ledger ever in the world” and encouraged people to register their support.

Vijay Verma was among the first to tweet and get trolled with threats of unfollow.

“You can do this quietly too. No need

to announce everything,” the actor posted in response.

No more Jaane Bhi Do Yaaron

Veteran actor Naseeruddin Shah, speaking emotionally after participating in the recent Delhi student protests, said he was “boiling with anger”. Asked why so many of his colleagues remained silent, he replied with a line that immediately went viral: “A dog with a bone in its mouth can’t bark.” Bollywood then, perhaps, is a mirror of India itself: risk-averse, scared into silence, politically divided and deeply aware that every public statement carries consequences.

Just as people have been emboldened to take to the streets in larger numbers.

Seen together, they reveal an industry caught between public expectations and political consequences.

Or, as Rajkummar Rao wrote while defending himself against criticism over a political campaign song, “One song does not define who I am, what I stand for or what my ideologies in life are.”

He ended that post with a line that perhaps explains Bollywood better than any political analysis can.

“You can never know the pressure.”

A little later, he quietly deleted it. But here’s to the braver voices. Like Dhurandhar actress Ayesha Khan wrote in her post after being trolled: “I rather have a spine than a career. Go scare someone else.”

(The writer is a film critic, filmmaker and screenwriter, most recently known for Culture Vulture, an indie on Bollywood’s relationship with politics)

THE DAILY QUIZ

On the death anniversary of Ingmar Bergman, test your knowledge of one of cinema’s greatest auteurs, whose films transformed the language of world cinema

Prathmesh Kher

QUESTION 1

In which Swedish city was Ingmar Bergman born in 1918?

QUESTION 2

Which Bergman film won the Academy Award for Best Foreign Language Film in 1961?

QUESTION 3

Identify the two Bergman films for which cinematographer Sven Nykvist won the Academy Award for Best Cinematography.

QUESTION 4

Despite sharing a surname and Swedish heritage, iconic actress Ingrid Bergman appeared in only one film directed by Ingmar Bergman. Name the film.

QUESTION 5

Ingmar Bergman died on July 30, 2007, the same day as which fellow European cinema giant?



Visual Question:

Ian McKellen plays Death in the Arnold Schwarzenegger starrer Last Action Hero. Which Bergman film is this scene paying homage to? COLUMBIA PICTURES INDUSTRIES, INC.

Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:

1. This U.S. President signed legislation to create NASA after the Soviet Union launched Sputnik 1. Name the President and the year when the legislation was created. **Ans: Dwight D. Eisenhower and 1958**
2. This Swedish Economist, who was born on this day, received the Nobel Peace Prize in 1961. He also served as the Secretary-General of the UN. Identify the economist. **Ans: Dag Hammarskjöld**
3. At an international summit held in 2010, it was decided that July 29 would be marked as International Tiger Day. Did India take part in the summit, and name the host country. **Ans: Yes and Russia**
4. The first part of this three-part fantasy novel series was published

on this day in 1954. The series was first revised and republished in 1965. Identify the title of the first book. **Ans: The Fellowship of the Ring**
5. The wedding of this royal couple on this day was watched by over 700 million people on television. It was broadcast in 74 countries. Identify the couple. **Ans: Prince Charles and Princess Diana**
Visual: A part of the wreckage of the Malaysian Airlines flight MH370 was found on the shore of Réunion Island in the Indian Ocean on July 29, 2015. What is the part called? **Ans: flaperon**
Early Birds: Siddhartha Viswanathan | Piya Tuli | Sitaram Saharay | Lalchand Bhutani | Tito Shiladitya



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“I was watching a movie last night and the hero kept saying ‘hang loose’. Any idea what it means?”

“When you tell someone to ‘hang loose’ or ‘stay loose’, you want him/her to remain calm.”

“If Roshni hangs loose she will definitely do well in the audition. How does that sound?”

“Sounds great.”
“When the Principal began to worry about the coming exams, I told him to hang loose.”

“I wouldn’t tell the Principal to hang loose if I were you. You see, the expression ‘hang loose’ is considered slang. It should be used only in informal contexts.”

“I see. Tell me, what...”
“...it’s unbearably hot today. Last night I just couldn’t sleep.”

“Hang loose. The summer is almost over.”

“What makes you say that?”

“It’s started raining in Kerala. So it should start raining here pretty soon.”

“I don’t want it to rain ‘in here’. I want it to rain here.”

“What’s the difference?”

“No, they don’t. When you say that you want it to rain ‘in here’, it means you want it to rain inside the room.”

“Rain inside the room! That happens every year during the monsoon season. You see, that’s how badly our roof leaks. So, if I say, ‘It snowed in here’, does it mean that it snowed inside the room?”

“That’s right. You don’t want that to happen, do you?”

“Given how hot it is right now, I wouldn’t mind a bit of snow inside the room.”

“You have a point there. But if you would like it to snow all over the city, then you have to say ‘here’ instead of ‘in here’.”

“I wish it would snow here.”

“I am sure many people would enjoy the experience.”

“Well, did you finally get a chance to meet your boss’ wife?”

“Yes, she came to the party last night. When she walked into the room, I had to do a double take. You see,”

“What does ‘double take’ mean?”

“When you do a double take, you react with surprise. For example,...”

“...is it like looking at something the second time just to make sure that I saw it correctly the first time?”

“I guess you could say that. Suppose your physics teacher returned your test paper and you found that she’s given you a hundred. How would you react?”

“I guess I would close my eyes and take another look just to see if I had seen it correctly the first time. You know, just to make sure that I wasn’t dreaming!”

“Well, in that case you would be doing a double take.”

“I think I understand now. Tell me about your boss’ wife. Why did you do a double take after seeing her?”

“She is really beautiful that’s why.”

“Is she a medium height woman?”

“You don’t say ‘a medium height woman’. A better way of saying the same thing is ‘of medium height’. Yes, my boss’ wife is a woman of medium height.”

“I see. The man who robbed the bank was of medium height. How does that sound?”

“Why do you always come up with examples where someone gets killed or robbed?”

“That’s me, I guess.”
Published in The Hindu on June 12, 2001

Word of the day

Punctilio:

a fine point of etiquette or petty formality

Synonyms:

formal, decorous, correct, nice

Usage:

Every punctilio of the ceremony was observed.

Pronunciation:

newsth.live/punctilio

International Phonetic Alphabet:

/ˈpʌŋktɪli.ə/

From Page One

Supreme Court restricts ‘retrospective’ approvals

The court said that the 2021-OM had indiscriminately allowed every permissible industry to be regularised for a meagre compensation. It had yielded to a principle of ‘pollute and then pay’, rather than to sustainable development. The top court quashed the 2021 OM prospectively to not upset ongoing projects, including the AIIMS Medical College and Hospital building in Odisha, the Centre of Excellence for Cancer Diseases in Tamil Nadu, Vijayapura Airport in Karnataka, medical colleges, slum rehabilitation and irrigation projects intended for drought-prone areas.

It said retrospective clearances given under 2017 notification, which provided a ‘one-time amnesty’ for undertakings started without prior clearance, and the 2021 OM would remain valid unless individually assailed in accordance with law.

The case has had a roller coaster ride with a Division Bench declaring such retrospective clearances a gross illegality in a May 2025 judgment.

In November last year, a larger Bench had diluted the judgment, reasoning that doing away with the retrospective clearance regime would have a “devastating effect” on ongoing public projects worth “thousands of crores of rupees”.

U.S. fast-tracks Russia sanctions tariff Act

A cloture is basically a Senate procedure that sets a time limit for the debate and related actions on an issue before it is put to a vote. That is, it is a procedure meant to hasten the vote on a particular issue. The original version of the Act, introduced in 2025, proposed a blanket 500% tariff on those importing Russian oil. However, the Act was revised in early July 2026.

Under the latest version of the Act, a tariff of “up to 100%” would be levied on the top five purchasers of Russian crude oil and natural gas. Currently, China accounts for about 47-50% of Russian crude oil exports, while India accounts for another 36-38%.

As per the latest Indian government data, Russian oil made up a little more than 40% of Indian oil imports in May 2026, and the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has told *The Hindu* that this rose to “more than half” in June.

“The stakes for India are substantial,” Ajay Srivastava, founder of the think tank Global Trade Research Initiative said. “Access to discounted Russian crude has significantly lowered India’s import bill, supported energy security, and helped contain inflation.”

“Washington is steadily expanding its use of trade and economic measures to pursue strategic objectives,” he added. “Reciprocal tariffs, Section 301 investigations, forced-labour measures, sector-specific duties, and now Russia-related sanctions reflect an increasingly broad toolkit of economic pressure.”

‘BS-III vehicles may need tweaks for E20 fuel’

Some users attributed the problems to E20 fuel or contaminated E20 fuel.

Fuel efficiency and mileage is influenced by “a host of factors beyond just fuel type”, Mr. Gadkari said, including, he added, driving habits, maintenance practices such as oil changes and air filter cleanliness, tyre pressure and alignment, and even air conditioning load.

After a brief pause, U.S. and Iran resume strikes

The war began on February 28 with U.S. and Israeli attacks on Iran. U.S. President Donald Trump said on Wednesday that the American military “will hit Iran hard” after the missile attack. “We will be hitting them hard. They are going to get a beating,” Fox News quoted Mr. Trump as saying, adding that he used swear words to emphasise his point.

The renewed hostilities sent oil prices spiking, with Brent crude jumping 3.1% to \$84.58 a barrel.

Mr. Trump also told Fox that U.S.-Saudi Arabia bombing of pro-Iranian militias overnight inside Iraq had been coordinated with the authorities in Baghdad – despite the Iraqi government publicly condemning the attacks.

The Jordanian military said five missiles had been “intercepted and destroyed.” Iran’s state-run IRNA news agency carried a statement from the paramilitary Revolutionary Guard saying the Guard’s Aerospace Force fired ballistic missiles at the Muwaffaq Salti Air Base and the headquarters of the U.S. military’s Central Command in Jordan.

Hours earlier, the U.S. Central Command said its forces “remain vigilant and at a high state of readiness”. In announcing the strikes against militias in Iraq, the U.S. warned that further attacks on American troops or Saudi Arabia’s energy infrastructure risked additional action.

Iraqi Prime Minister Ali al-Zaidi called an emergency meeting of the country’s National Security Council on Wednesday to discuss the strikes.

Two Iraqi government officials said a visit to Saudi by Mr. al-Zaidi that had been scheduled for Thursday had been postponed, without another date being set.

India getting ready for Xi, Putin visits in September

Both leaders expected to attend BRICS summit in Delhi on Sept. 12, 13; Foreign Secretary holds wide-ranging talks in Beijing as Chinese officials arrive in Delhi to oversee security preparations

Ananth Krishnan
Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

India is getting ready for visits by Chinese President Xi Jinping and Russian President Vladimir Putin, with both leaders planning to attend the BRICS summit to be held in Delhi on September 12 and 13, sources here said on Wednesday. Consultations are continuing with regard to these upcoming high-level visits.

On Monday and Tuesday, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri held a series of talks in Beijing, during which both sides discussed “strengthening high-level interactions”. In recent weeks, Chinese officials have also visited India to oversee the arrangements and security preparations for a possible high-level visit.

During Mr. Misri’s talks in Beijing with a senior Communist Party of China official Sun Haiyan, who is Vice Minister in the party’s



High-level meet: Narendra Modi, Vladimir Putin and Xi Jinping at the BRICS Summit in Kazan, Russia, in October 2024. REUTERS
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9>
International Department, both sides “expressed commitment to working together to follow through on the common understandings reached by the leaders, strengthen high-level interactions, properly manage differences, and make sustained efforts to foster the improvement and development of bilateral relations,” according to a readout from the Chinese side.

The Ministry of External Affairs said both sides had “discussed ways to deepen implementation of the

way for the subsequent gradual normalisation in relations.

India intensifies contact
Mr. Putin’s attendance at the summit was earlier indicated by the Russian side when Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov visited New Delhi for the BRICS Foreign Ministers meeting in May and discussed “highest level” contacts with External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar.

India has intensified contact with BRICS member countries both bilaterally and under the multilateral BRICS umbrella.

Official sources here indicated that they expect top leaders of the member countries to attend the summit meeting, though the final details of the visits will be known closer to the date of the summit.

Russia has extended support to India’s chairmanship of BRICS and China reiterated its support earlier this week during Mr. Misri’s visit.

Centre’s assurance cannot override statutory processes on withdrawal of FIRs, experts say

Aaratrika Bhaumik
NEW DELHI

Even as the Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) contended that the Supreme Court’s interim order permitting the States to proceed with the investigation into the FIRs registered against student protesters was in “direct contradiction” to the Centre’s assurance that no punitive action would be taken against them, legal experts said the assurance could not override the statutory provisions governing the criminal process.

Once an FIR has been registered, they pointed out, the investigating agency may file a closure report if it finds no material to proceed, or the public prosecutor may seek withdrawal from prosecution in accordance with law.

Notably, during the hearing on Tuesday, Solicitor-General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the Centre and the Delhi Police, made no reference to any assurance by the Centre that protesters would be granted amnesty. Instead, he submitted that the violence during the protests may have been caused by “anti-social elements” and miscreants who had infiltrated the demonstrations.



“It is doubtful whether the Union government can give an assurance to the court on behalf of the State governments regarding the closure of criminal cases registered by the State police. Except for the Delhi Police, the police are under the control of the State governments, not the Centre,” said Abhay S. Oka, a former judge of the Supreme Court. “Moreover, once an FIR has been registered, it cannot simply be cancelled or deregistered,” he added.

Mr. Oka explained that if the investigating agency finds no evidence against the accused, it may file a closure report. Alternatively, if the prosecution seeks to withdraw the case before the judgment is pronounced, the public prosecutor may move an application, he said.

Judicial scrutiny
He, however, stressed that both these routes remain subject to judicial scrutiny.

“Even if the investigating officer files a closure report, the court is not bound to accept it. After hearing the complainant, it may either accept or reject the report. Likewise, if the public prosecutor seeks to withdraw a case before

SC closes coal block scam case against Manmohan Singh

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



The Supreme Court on Wednesday provided former Prime Minister Dr. Manmohan Singh posthumous relief by agreeing with two back-to-back closure reports filed by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) in 2014 giving him a clean chit, while highlighting there was no “sufficient material or good reason” to register a corruption case against him in connection with the coal block allocation scam.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the apex court would have ordinarily dismissed the case as infructuous solely on the ground of the demise of the appellant, however, the Bench said it had gone through the closure reports filed in the trial court, only to discover the trial judge had no “compelling reason” to reject the closure reports and make adverse observations against the former PM.

Singh passed away in December 2024, but the

Fresh cases of detentions, takedown of online posts reported

Vijaita Singh
Shweta Mishra
NEW DELHI

The fallout from the protests demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan continued, with many reports of people, including minors, being detained or arrested by the police, and social media users being asked to take down posts related to the agitation.

A 21-year-old man, who was detained by the police in Uttar Pradesh’s Prayagraj after being identified from a photo taken while participating in a protest on July 26, was released on Wednesday. The victim said he was beaten up in police custody. The police wrongly accused him of vandalising a private vehicle belonging to a BJP member, he said.

‘Parents summoned’
“They first called my father to the police station and then my mother. It was then that I went and surrendered... I was merely there to protest, I was not involved in vandalism, yet I was kept in detention for more than a day,” he said.

When contacted, a police official who answered the phone of the Deputy Commissioner of Police, Prayagraj City, said, “Nobody has been detained. People had been called for questioning based on CCTV footage, but they were released.” Ten others were arrested in the case.

Rishav Ranjan of the Congress’s legal cell said a 17-year-old boy from Bhagalpur in Bihar, who participated in a protest, was picked up by the police from his home around 3.45 a.m. on July 26. He was among 40 others who were detained or arrested by the Bhagalpur Police.

Atulesh Jha, City Superintendent of Police, said, “As per the assurance given by the government, the case... is being withdrawn... and he has been released.”

Several Instagram users claimed that the videos related to the July 20 protests were being taken down.

Sailors’ safety ‘highest priority’, says Indian Embassy in Ukraine

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Hours after the Forward Seamen’s Union of India (FSUI) issued an urgent appeal in view of a “life threatening” situation for 13 Indian seafarers on board a commercial vessel in the Black Sea, the Indian Embassy in Ukraine has taken note of the issue and said that it is attaching “highest priority” to the matter.

“A situation regarding *MV AMIRI* with Indian seafarers onboard has been brought to our attention. We attach the highest priority to this and are in constant touch with all concerned to ensure safety and security of all Indians on board,” the Indian Embassy said in a post on social media.

15 seafarers trapped
Earlier on Tuesday, the FSUI issued an ‘Urgent Appeal’ regarding *MV AMIRI* saying that 13 Indian sailors

are among the ship’s 15 crew members who are “trapped in a terrible and life-threatening situation”.

“Repeated drone and missile attacks are being attempted in the immediate vicinity of the vessel. The crew is living under constant fear of a direct hit at any moment. We urgently appeal to all concerned authorities, ship owners, flag state, and the Government of India to immediately secure their safety and arrange prompt repatriation. Indian seafarers must not be left as sitting targets in conflict zones,” the FSUI said in a statement late Tuesday evening.

India had issued an advisory for its seafarers on July 26 against the backdrop of frequent attacks on civilian merchant vessels in the Black Sea and nearby regions that have emerged as the maritime front of Russia-Ukraine conflict.

Govt. simplifies NEET-UG counselling procedure

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Union Health Minister J.P. Nadda on Tuesday reviewed the preparedness for the forthcoming NEET-UG counselling 2026.

The government has introduced several technology-enabled and student-centric reforms aimed at enhancing transparency in counselling, improving accessibility and simplifying the admission process.

One of the key reforms is the introduction of a one-time physical reporting framework aimed at reducing the need for repeat visits. Following seat allotment, candidates will be able to exercise their willingness online by selecting either the ‘Freeze or Float’ option.

Those opting for the freeze option will physically report to their allotted institute within the prescribed schedule to complete admission formalities, including verification of documents and pay-



ment of the admission fee.

Those opting for the float option for participating in subsequent rounds for upgradation will be able to complete admission formalities through the online mode within the stipulated timeline.

During this period, they will not be required to physically report to the allotted institute, submit original documents or pay the admission fee. Their provisional admission will remain valid while participating in subsequent counselling rounds.

The upgradation facility will remain available up to the third round of coun-

selling. After completion of the third round, candidates holding allotted seats will report physically to their institutions for verification of original documents, payment of admission fees and completion of institutional formalities.

Online resignation
Candidates wishing to forego their allotted seat will now be able to submit their resignation through the MCC Counselling Portal without the need to visit the allotted institute.

Special emphasis has been placed on improving accessibility for Persons with Benchmark Disabilities (PwBD). The Ministry has fully digitised the admission process under the NRI category. The review also highlighted several steps to strengthen operational efficiency, including online document verification, validation of the seat matrix by the National Medical Commission and verification by participating institutes.

LS passes paper leak Bill amid Opposition protests

No shots were fired at students during the July 20 protest and ‘utmost restraint was exercised’ by the police, says Minister; ‘I brought before you a boy who suffered pellet gun injury’, says Rahul

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Union Minister Jitendra Singh on Wednesday insisted that “no shots were fired” at students during the July 20 protest in Delhi, rejecting Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi’s allegation that Home Minister Amit Shah had ordered security forces to open fire on the protesters. He was replying to the debate on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026.

The Bill, which proposes tightening penalties and introducing time-bound investigations and trials for paper leak cases, was passed amid Opposition protests over the alleged police excesses against students during the NEET-UG agitation. Soon after its passage, Mr. Shah hailed the legislation in a post on X, congratulating students across the country and describing the amendment as



Centre’s stand: Union Minister Jitendra Singh speaks in the Lok Sabha on the paper leak Bill on Wednesday. ANI

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9> a measure that would “shield the dreams and aspirations” of the youth.

“The Modi govt. will spare no one who attempts to imperil the future of our students and will leave no stone unturned to ensure that they face the full wrath of the law,” the Minister said. However, he did not respond to the charges that Mr. Gandhi sought to raise inside the Lok Sabha in his speech.

Dr. Singh, who is the Minister of State in the Prime Minister’s Office and han-

dles the Department of Personnel and Training, responded to the charge while replying to the debate on the paper leak Bill.

‘Utmost restraint’
He said “utmost restraint was exercised” during the police action and “it was made sure that casualties do not happen”. Mr. Singh accused the Congress of attempting to politicise a legislation aimed at safeguarding the integrity of public examinations.

The Minister said the

amendments reflected an willingness to “learn from experience” after the implementation of the 2024 anti-paper leak law. So far, 52 FIRs had been registered since the original law came into force and suicides linked to paper leaks had declined, he informed the Lok Sabha.

Responding to the government’s assertion that no shots had been fired, Mr. Gandhi stood by his charge.

“I brought before you a boy who suffered pellet gun injury. He could lose an eye and the pellet gun is a lethal weapon. And the government is saying I am lying. What do you want me to do? Bring the gun?” he said.

The amendments significantly strengthen the 2024 law. They mandate that investigations be completed within two months and empower States and Union Territories to designate sessions courts as fast-track special courts to conduct day-to-day trials.

Rahul Gandhi hits out at Centre, RSS in Lok Sabha over protests crackdown

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday launched a scathing attack on the government in the Lok Sabha over the students’ protest in the capital last week, drawing sharp rebuttals from the ruling NDA.

Mr. Gandhi could not complete his speech amid protests and objections from the Treasury benches, even as a substantial part of the address was expunged from the records.

Participating in the debate on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, he took an indirect dig at the BJP and its core supporters by referring to three categories of people – students, those who think they know everything and pretend to be god, and “*andhbhaks*” (blind believers) who believe the second category is god.

The Treasury benches erupted in protest over the remarks, and as the uproar



Vociferous attack: Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi speaks in the Lok Sabha on Wednesday. ANI

continued, Mr. Gandhi claimed that he was not being allowed to speak.

He said that Dharmendra Pradhan, who had to resign as the Union Education Minister, was just a symbol and the Education Ministry was actually being run by the RSS.

At this, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju and Defence Minister Rajnath Singh stood up and said that the Leader of the Opposition had the responsibility of not using unparliamentary words.

Mr. Gandhi targeted the RSS, alleging that it was in-

fluencing the education system. “The soul of the system has been captured by the RSS. Mr. Pradhan never ran the Education Ministry. The man and organisation that run the Ministry is called the RSS,” he said.

Mr. Gandhi then trained his guns at Union Home Minister Amit Shah, claiming that he was not present in the Lok Sabha because he was “scared”.

The BJP demanded that Mr. Gandhi apologise for “misusing” the House by making “baseless” allegations.

RS passes Bill to criminalise disrespect to Vande Mataram

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Rajya Sabha passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 on Wednesday, in the absence of members from Opposition parties.

After raising slogans demanding an apology from Union Home Minister Amit Shah for last week’s police action against protesting students, the Opposition walked out as Union Minister of State for Social Jus-

tice and Empowerment Ramdas Athawale started speaking about the Bill.

The Bill proposes to amend the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act, 1971, and extend the punishment for acts of disrespect towards national symbols such as the National Flag, the Constitution, and the National Anthem, to acts causing obstruction in the singing of the National Song, *Vande Mataram*.

The Bill will now go to the Lok Sabha for its con-



Nityanand Rai

sideration and passage.

Replying to the brief discussion on the Bill, which largely saw the participation of NDA members, Minister of State for Home Af-

fairs Nityanand Rai said the Congress was engaging in appeasement politics by insulting *Vande Mataram* for many years.

“The *Vande Mataram* Bill is not merely an ordinary Bill, but represents India’s soul, national awareness, and cultural heritage, and reminds us of the freedom struggle,” Mr. Rai said, asking why the Congress opposed the Bill.

Vande Mataram was penned by Bankim Chandra Chatterjee in 1875, but only two stanzas were Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGjOKH6oBd0F>

adopted as the National Song, with Congress leader Jawaharlal Nehru making that decision in 1937, years before he became the country’s first Prime Minister.

Penal provisions

“Don’t know why a few people are opposed to *Vande Mataram*, or why Congress is particularly opposed to *Vande Mataram*,” Mr. Rai said. “There has been a discussion about making penal provisions for disrespecting the national song

through this Bill. Opposing *Vande Mataram* means the Congress has been always working to disrespect the pride of this country by adopting a policy of appeasement.”

The Aam Aadmi Party’s Sanjay Singh said that his party believed that *Vande Mataram* and the National Anthem should not be insulted. The Bill was passed by voice vote. The House was adjourned after Mr. Harivanish allowed some members to place special mentions in the House.

Backlog of cases, timely completion of paper leak probe among challenges

NEWS ANALYSIS

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

Following widespread protests over the NEET-UG, 2026 paper leak issue, the Union government introduced the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 in the Lok Sabha.

While the Bill was introduced with the objective of curbing examination malpractices through time-bound investigations and speedy trials, it faces certain limitations with regard to timely completion of investigations. It may also lead to a growing backlog of cases, as has been observed under other similarly enacted laws.

The Bill has enhanced the period of debarment of service providers engaging in unfair means from four years to eight and empowers the Union government to constitute a special task force to investigate offences. The Bill states that the investigation of an offence must be completed within two months. However, it does not contain any provision for instances where the investigation deadline is not met.

“This is different from other laws. For instance, The Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act, 2013 requires rea-



Bill lacks clarity on provisions if probe timeline is surpassed

sons to be recorded in writing for extending time period for preliminary inquiry and investigation,” an analysis by PRS Legislative Research states. “Similarly, under the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act, 1989, the officer must explain the delay in completing investigation and filing chargesheet within 60 days, in writing.”

The amendment Bill requires that trial must be completed within three months from the date of filing of the chargesheet.

“This may contradict a Supreme Court ruling. The court in 2002 held that it is neither advisable, nor feasible, nor judicially permissible to draw or prescribe an outer limit for conclusion of criminal proceedings. It further held that criminal courts are not obliged to terminate trials or criminal proceedings merely on account of lapse of time,” the PRS analysis

states. For organised crimes, the amendment Bill proposes a minimum sentence of seven years and a fine of up to ₹10 crore, up from the ₹1 crore in the anti-cheating law passed in 2024.

The new Bill empowers States and Union Territories to designate a sessions court as a special fast-track court for speedy adjudication. Similarly, fast-track courts have been set up under other laws too. For example, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences Act, 2012 also provides for designation of a sessions court as a special court, for each district.

The major challenge in the operation of fast-track special courts is the pendency of cases, apart from the fact that the average time taken in disposing of the cases widely varies between States.

As of April 2026, 775 fast-track special courts were functional, including 398 exclusive POCSO courts. “These courts have had more than two lakh pending cases since 2023,” the analysis says.

It is pertinent to note that the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act passed in 2024 following the uproar over the earlier NEET-UG paper leak case has not secured any conviction over the past two years.

Opposition to raise Ram Temple issue in Parliament

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

An emerging consensus is taking shape within the INDIA bloc that the Opposition should continue pursuing the Ram Temple embezzlement case in Parliament. The Samajwadi Party (SP), which has been raising the matter during meetings of Opposition parties, staged a protest in the Parliament House complex on Wednesday.

According to senior Opposition leaders, it was decided that the issue will be taken up in the Lok Sabha on Thursday and in the Rajya Sabha after the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 is cleared. The Opposition wants to seek a discussion on the al-

BJP govt. in U.P. took action only against peripheral players in the embezzlement case, says SP

leged embezzlement of donations at the Ayodhya Ram temple.

Speaking to reporters, SP president Akhilesh Yadav said the alleged diversion of donations reflected the BJP government’s failure to safeguard public faith. “The issue is the same. Those who could not protect donation boxes and the offerings made by devotees cannot be expected to prevent paper leaks or stop examinations from being cancelled. Those who can play with people’s faith can also play with the

future of our youth,” he said.

At the Makar Dwar, SP MPs held donation boxes with currency notes placed on top and raised slogans against the BJP government, chanting “*chanda chor, gaddi chhod*” (donation thieves, vacate your seats) and waving placards. The SP has argued that the BJP government in Uttar Pradesh has arrested only peripheral players in the alleged scam while shielding those responsible for planning it.

Several Opposition leaders had initially expressed reservations about whether the INDIA bloc should take up the issue, fearing it could communalise a narrative that has largely remained focused on policy matters.

Rahul is spreading misinformation, he must apologise: BJP

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Wednesday demanded an apology from the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, for what it described as spreading misinformation in an attempt to create confusion, provoke unrest, and derive political benefit.

At a press conference, BJP MP and spokesperson Sambit Patra said Mr. Gandhi falsely claimed in the Lok Sabha that bullets were fired at the students’ march on July 20. Since no such incident occurred, his charge that Amit Shah ordered the firing was also false, Mr. Patra said. The allegation was also inaccurate because decisions about the use of force are taken by the area magistrate, and not the Home Minister, he said.

“During the movements in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, you shot and killed hundreds of students. In Jammu & Kashmir, you fired bullets. In Assam, you fired on the As-

Rahul seeks Shah’s ouster, vows justice for students

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

Escalating the confrontation with the Narendra Modi government over the use of force and lethal weapons such as pellet guns against protesting students during their March towards Parliament on July 20, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday demanded the dismissal of Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

“There are only two possibilities: either [Amit] Shah ordered the use of lethal weapons or he was not aware of it. He is either culpable or incapable and in both cases, he has to go,” Mr. Gandhi said.

Addressing a press conference at Indira Bhavan, Mr. Gandhi also said that the “balloon” of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s “fake image” had already burst.

Seeking to reassure students injured in the protests, Mr. Gandhi said the Opposition would pursue accountability. “We will ensure that every single student gets justice.”



Sambit Patra

sam students’ union and brutally killed over 800 students,” Mr. Patra said.

He countered Mr. Gandhi’s charge that he was not allowed to speak in the Lok Sabha. “Rahul Gandhi alleged that Ministers Kiren Rijiju and Rajnath Singh interrupted his speech... the objections raised a couple of times by Mr. Rijiju was about the use of unparliamentary word ‘idiot’ by Mr. Gandhi,” he said.

He rejected Mr. Gandhi’s claim that Mr. Shah was “trembling” inside a car, saying that the Home Minister was a strong leader who had taken decisive action against Naxalism and terrorism.

INBRIEF



LIC pays ₹12,207.25 crore dividend to government

Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) on Wednesday paid ₹12,207.25 crore dividend to the Centre. CEO and MD R. Doraiswamy presented the dividend cheque, for ₹12,207.25 crore, to Union Minister of Finance Nirmala Sitharaman as the government of India's share of dividend, LIC said. The shareholders had given their approval at the annual general meeting on July 27. LIC said it is completing 70 years and as on March 31, 2026 the asset base stood at ₹59.03 lakh crore.

SBI raises ₹4,691 crore via Additional Tier 1 bonds

State Bank of India has raised ₹4,691 crore through its first Basel III compliant Additional Tier 1 (AT1) bonds to part fund the growth strategy, signifying its ability to diversify and raise long term non-equity regulatory capital. This is the first Tier I bonds issuance in the ongoing financial year. “This issue attracted a robust response from investors with bids of more than two times against the base issue size of ₹3,000 crore,” SBI said in a statement.

Parliamentary panel calls for upgrading coal washery infra

The quality of domestically produced coal with high-ash content remains a “major challenge, the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Coal, Mines and Steel stated in its latest report, calling for increased priority to coal beneficiation and modernisation of washery infrastructure for increasing availability of higher quality coal. Specifically, on logistical constraints, the committee called for the ministry to institute washeries “at or near pitheads”.

Govt. must continue E10 supply, says Team Bharat amid E20 row

Saptaparno Ghosh
NEW DELHI

Amid growing concerns over the impact of E20 fuel on vehicles, citizens' advocacy group Team Bharat met officials from the Union Petroleum Ministry, urging the government to continue supplying E10 petrol (petrol with 10% ethanol) for vehicles designed to use it even as it demanded pure petrol with no ethanol blending be made available at all fuel stations at affordable prices.

The citizens'-advocacy group, founded by political commentator and observer Tehseen Poonawalla, Real Creator IAS Edition https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F



Team Bharat with Union Minister Hardeep Puri.

put forth the demands at a meeting with Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Puri.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Poonawalla said Team Bharat also called for E20

being made available at 20% discount to the pure petrol variant being sought. The group also sought relevant documents and reports on E20 fuel to be in the public domain for transparency.

Also, they called for a mechanism and rules to assess how vehicles may have been damaged because of the blended fuel, along with procedures to address the grievances.

Making it clear Team Bharat has not called for a complete rollback of the E20 fuel, Mr. Poonawalla said “The government has come forward to discuss concerns, we are thus striving for a middle-ground acceptable to all.”

The group also raised concerns about a potential conflict of interest allegedly involving Union Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari in relation to the overall blending programme.

The outreach assumes significance in the wake of furore over E20. *The Hindu* also reached out to officials at the Union Petroleum Ministry for a comment.

Separately, sources told *The Hindu* the government and Team Bharat at the next meeting would be working on a mechanism to inspect vehicles reportedly damaged due to E20.

Q2 net income slips to \$636 mn at Cognizant

Balasubramanyam C. P.
CHENNAI

Cognizant net income for the second quarter ended June 30 slid to \$636 million from \$645 million a year earlier. Q2 revenue rose 4.5% to \$5.48 billion. Operating margin expanded 30 basis points to 15.9%.

Financial Services, Cognizant's largest business segment, posted 12% year-on-year revenue growth to \$1.73 billion.

Stating that “40% of software development in the firm is AI assisted”, CEO Ravi Kumar S., on an earnings call, said AI represented significantly larger long-term opportunity for technology services firms, estimating the \$1 trillion systems integration market could expand into a \$5-6 trillion enterprise opera-

Cognizant revised downward 2026 constant currency revenue growth guidance to 4%-5.5%

tions market with \$4.5 trillion of operational labour exposed to AI.

For the third quarter, Cognizant expects revenue of \$5.60-\$5.68 billion, representing a growth of 3.4%-4.9%, or 3.8%-5.3% in constant currency.

Cognizant revised downward its 2026 constant currency revenue growth guidance to 4%-5.5% from 4-6.5% earlier.

The IT services provider ended the quarter with 3,56,700 employees while voluntary attrition at the company over the last 12 months stood at 13%.

\$275mn U.S. deal hits Adani Enterprises Q1

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Adani Enterprises Ltd (AEL), the holding firm of the Adani Group, suffered a consolidated net loss of ₹1,160 crore in the June ended quarter of FY27 on a one-time settlement of \$275 million (₹2,644 crore) relating to U.S. Office of Foreign Assets Control.

This is AEL's consolidated net loss for the second straight quarter even as the flagship Adani Group firm saw record quarterly operating profit on the back of growth in airports and copper businesses.

The one-time charge had a significant impact on the firm's reported net earnings in the quarter as AEL had reported net profit of ₹855 crore in the corresponding period of the



This is AEL's consolidated net loss for second straight quarter.

previous year.

Excluding this exceptional settlement, core business remained profitable as earnings before interest, taxes, depreciation and amortisation (EBITDA) grew 49% year-on-year. Profit before tax stood at ₹1,295 crore (excluding OFAC settlement of ₹2,644 crore). Revenue from operations rose by almost 50% YoY to ₹32,924 crore.

Private R&D spends cross govt.'s in FY24

A level last seen in 2009-10, official data reveal a structural shift: private industry accounted for 45.5% of national R&D spending in 2021-22, rising further to 51.8% in 2023-24, the first time businesses have contributed more to India's research effort than all levels of government combined

Jacob P Koshy
NEW DELHI

India's spending on research and development (R&D) surged to 0.83% of GDP in 2021-22, the first time that the country crossed the 0.8% threshold – a level last seen in 2009-10, according to newly disclosed government data.

The figures also reveal a structural shift in India's innovation landscape: private industry accounted for 45.5% of national R&D spending in 2021-22, rising further to 51.8% in 2023-24, the first time businesses have contributed more to India's research effort than all levels of government combined.

The figures were disclosed by the Department of Science and Technology (DST) in response to a Lok Sabha question on Wednesday. They form part of the latest Research & Development Statistics 2025-26,

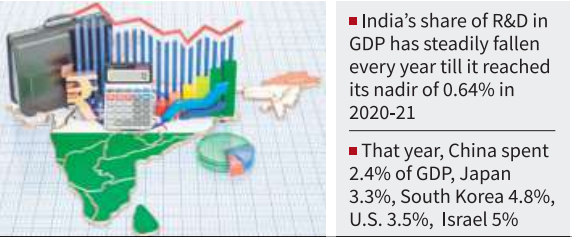
although the full statistical report itself has not yet been publicly released.

The numbers are significant because India, despite possessing one of the world's largest scientific workforces and ranking among the top countries in scientific publications, has long spent a much smaller share of its economy on research than major scientific powers. The share of R&D in GDP – long considered a bellwether of progress – has, in the case of India, steadily fallen every year till it reached its nadir of 0.64% in 2020-21.

That year China spent 2.4% of GDP, Japan 3.3%, South Korea 4.8%, United States 3.5% and around 5% in Israel. Successive governments have also repeatedly argued that India's innovation ecosystem is constrained because industry contributes a much smaller share of national R&D spending than in advanced economies, where

Science wins

The numbers are significant because India has long spent a much smaller share of its economy on research than major scientific powers



Real Creator IAS Edition https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9 business routinely accounts for over 70% of research expenditure.

DST compiles India's official R&D statistics through its National Science and Technology Management Information System (NSTMIS), which has conducted national science surveys since 1973 using UNESCO and OECD definitions. The surveys gather expenditure data from central and state government agencies, universities, public sector enterprises and private

data only up to 2020-21. The parliamentary reply is therefore the first official disclosure of India's R&D expenditure for 2021-22, 2022-23 and 2023-24, even though the corresponding statistical reports have yet to be published.

The fresh data point to an abrupt discontinuity. Gross Expenditure on Research and Development (GERD) fell from ₹1.33 lakh crore in 2019-20 to ₹1.27 lakh crore in 2020-21 (a COVID-year slump), before jumping 53% to ₹1.95 lakh crore in 2021-22. It subsequently rose to ₹2.13 lakh crore in 2022-23 and ₹2.45 lakh crore in 2023-24.

However, budget documents from the period do not suggest a commensurate surge in government science spending. Union allocations to the Department of Science and Technology, Department of Biotechnology, Department of Atomic Energy, ISRO and other major science agen-

cies rose only incrementally across these years, making it unlikely that the increase was driven solely by public expenditure.

The sharp rise in GERD coincided with a dramatic increase in the private sector industry's contribution to India's research spending. Private industry accounted for 38.5% of GERD in 2017-18, 37.7% in 2018-19, 33.8% in 2019-20 and 36.4% in 2020-21, before jumping to 45.5% in 2021-22, 48.0% in 2022-23 and 51.8% in 2023-24 – the first time private industry has contributed more than half of India's total R&D expenditure. In absolute terms, Industry R&D spending increased from about ₹43,800 crore in 2017-18 and ₹46,700 crore in 2018-19 to ₹44,800 crore in 2019-20 and ₹46,400 crore in 2020-21, before almost doubling to ₹88,600 crore in 2021-22 and rising further to ₹126,800 crore in 2023-24.

IRDAI okays reforms, policyholder fund norms, new general insurer

Special Correspondent
HYDERABAD

Insurance regulator IRDAI approved various reforms, including the Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF) regulations, besides permitting a new general insurer, at its meeting on Tuesday.

On PEPF, IRDAI said the Fund will be a dedicated institutional mechanism to promote insurance awareness and literacy initiatives, strengthen grievance redressal mechanisms and facilitate tracing and recovery of unclaimed insurance amounts.

Other reforms included

introduction of perpetual registration supported by an annual fee regime instead of periodic renewals; and regulations governing penalties. Approving grant of certificate of registration to ProTec General Insurance, IRDAI said since January this is the fourth registration.

‘Maruti is top EV exporter in Q1 FY27’

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Maruti Suzuki India Ltd, which entered the electric vehicle (EV) segment last

year, exported 15,210 EVs in Q1FY27, commanding a 97% share in total EV shipments from the country.

The EV market, dominated by Tata Motors and

Mahindra, registered total exports of 15,641 units in the review period, as per available industry data.

Maruti, the market leader in the passenger vehi-

cles segment, had in August 2025 unveiled eVitara and since then, exported more than 41,000 units to 47 countries with the U.K. being the top destination.

BLITZING AWAY

Cameroon's Esemé emerges the fastest man in record time



REUTERS

Emmanuel Esemé stormed through torrential rain in Glasgow to claim the men's 100m gold for Cameroon in a new Games record time of 9.83 seconds. Lachlan Kennedy of Australia claimed silver (9.85s) ahead of Nigeria's Kanyinsola Ajayi (9.90). Esemé's time was .05 seconds better than Ato Boldon's effort at Kuala Lumpur in 1998.

GLORIOUS

New Zealand's Hobbs surges to women's 100m gold



AFF

New Zealand's Zoe Hobbs produced a remarkable run from lane seven to win the women's 100m final at the Commonwealth Games. Hobbs, a 60m specialist, won in 10.93 seconds in sodden conditions in Glasgow. England's Amy Hunt took silver (10.98) ahead of Australia's Torrie Lewis (10.99).

AUSSIE POWER

Patterson bests compatriot Olyslagers for high jump crown



AFF

Australia's Eleanor Patterson (1.96m) overcame the challenge of compatriot and World champion Nicola Olyslagers (1.93) to win her second high jump crown — 12 years after her first Commonwealth Games title in 2014. Nigeria's Temitope Adeshina won bronze with a jump of 1.90m, even as India's Pooja finished eighth (1.77).

AUSTRALIAN DOMINATION

Pallister and Forrester swim to their third gold medals



AFF

Australia's ace swimmer Lani Pallister added the 800m gold to her 400m and 1,500m titles on Wednesday even as Jenna Forrester won her third gold in the 200m individual medley and Flynn Southam took the men's 100m freestyle. Australia, which set a Games record in the 4x100m men's medley relay, has won 28 golds in the pool.

Gulveer braves weather and competition to bag silver

He becomes the first man from the India to win a medal in the 10,000m event in the Games' history, finishing with a timing of 27:49.78s; Australia's Robinson clinches gold (27:48.93s)

C'WEALTH GAMES

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

While much of the spotlight was on India assuring itself of medals in the boxing ring at the Commonwealth Games here, a few kilometres away at the Scotstoun Stadium, a middle-distance runner from the country was quietly scripting history. In challenging track conditions with heavy rain and sun making frequent appearances, Gulveer Singh won silver (27:49.78s) in the men's 10,000m on Tuesday to become the first Indian man to win a medal in the event in the Games' history.

Ky Robinson of Australia won gold in a time of 27:48.93 while David Mulroney of the Isle of Man bagged bronze in 27:50.28. Gulveer was one of the favourites to bag a medal. Before the race, he was in the top three in season's best and his personal best of 27:00.22 (a National record) was at the top in the field.

Gulveer ran a tactical



Final push: Gulveer broke away from the pack with around 900m left, even as Australia's Robinson claimed gold. GETTY IMAGES

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F> race, being among the leaders till the last before accelerating. He stayed in sixth position at the 8,000m mark with five more laps to go. With around 900m left, he broke out of the pack. Gulveer, who has improved since joining hands with coach Scott Simmons

in the USA three years ago, brought out his best in a strong field that also included Daniel Ebenyo, the 2023 World champion-silver medalist. Ebenyo ended up sixth while the other Kenyans, Edwin Kurgat and Ishmael Kipkurgu finished fourth and 10th respectively.

Wrapping himself in Indian tricolour, Gulveer was gasping for breath when he came to the mixed zone. "It was not easy to run in the conditions. I take this opportunity to thank my family, coaches and the Athletics Federation of India for their support," he said.

Harjinder — from the farms of Punjab to the Glasgow podium

K. Keerthivasan
GLASGOW

Harjinder Kaur's smile is truly infectious. After successfully completing her clean and jerk attempt, she genuflected to the crowd, waved her hands in acknowledgement and happily slow-jogged back to the coaches' area.

It was a special moment for the 29-year-old, who had improved on her bronze medal from the previous Commonwealth Games by clinching silver this time in the 69kg weightlifting competition of the Glasgow Games at the Scottish Event Campus here on Tuesday.

Stiff competition

Amidst stiff competition, Harjinder held her own and didn't wilt under pressure claiming the silver medal with a total lift of 227kg behind Charlotte Simoneau of Canada who lifted a total of 240kg to win the gold.

Charlotte, a two-time junior World champion in 2024 and 2025, was the show-stealer as the 21-year-old created a Games record in snatch (108kg), a Commonwealth and Games record in clean and jerk (132kg), and Games record in snatch (240kg).



Gritty effort: Harjinder's consistency earned her a silver medal. GETTY IMAGES

Real Creator IAS Edition <https://t.me/+8B98m5PQCF84MmQ9> zone with 'Finnie', the Commonwealth Games mascot, in the hands and cameras flashing, her smile seemed brighter than ever.

For me to do well in weightlifting, my parents focused on my diet, shoes and kits, sacrificing a lot of things in the process

But Harjinder was focused on the task at hand, not on reputations. She executed all six of her lifts — three in snatch and three in clean and jerk — with remarkable composure, not failing a single attempt.

On a stage where consistency was as valuable as strength, Harjinder did exactly what she had set out to do.

When Harjinder finally walked into the mixed

There was a distinct glow about her, one that reflected not just the joy of winning silver but also the many sacrifices her parents had made to help her reach this stage.

On her day at the big arena, Harjinder didn't forget her family. "My family played an important role. For me to do well in weightlifting, my parents focussed on my diet, shoes and kits, sacrificing a lot of things in the process. It was a bit of struggle and I used to help my father in farming at Mehas (Patiala district of Punjab)," she said.

Shot putters Toor and Samardeep enter final

Press Trust of India
GLASGOW

Indian shot putters Tajinderpal Singh Toor and Samardeep Singh Gill did not have to exert much as they qualified for the final round of the Commonwealth Games here on Wednesday.

National record holder Toor took two attempts to breach the automatic qualification mark of 20m in Group A. His first effort measured 19.93m before coming up with 20.14m in his second throw. It was the second best distance overall. He did not take the third attempt.

In qualification round Group B, Samardeep's best of the day was 19.95m which came in his opening attempt. His second throw measured 19.75m and the third was a foul.

Samardeep finished fifth overall out of 15 who competed across the two groups. Those who breach the 20m mark or the 12

best performers qualify for the finals to be held on Thursday.

Meanwhile, National record holder Animesh Kujur clocked his season best time to qualify for the 200m semifinals.

The 23-year-old ran in 20.46s to win Heat 4 in round one races and finish seventh overall. The 16 fastest from across 10 heats advance to the semifinals to be held on Thursday.

In the para swimming competition, Chaitanya Vishwas Kulkarni and Suyash Narayan Jadhav entered the S7 50m freestyle finals. Chaitanya was fourth in the Heats at 32.77s while Suyash was sixth with a timing of 35.35s.

Other Indian results: **Weightlifting: Women's 77kg:** Sajana (DNF). **Swimming: Men's 200m freestyle:** Sajjan Prakash (1:51.99s, fifth in his heat and 20th overall); Aneesh Gowda (1:51.64s, seventh in his heat and 18th overall).



Sealing it: Toor threw 20.14m in his second attempt. REUTERS



Punching a medal: Narender (red) had to stretch every sinew while Sachin (blue) was hardly tested by his opponent. Sakshi (blue) and Ankush (red) sailed smoothly into the next round. PTI & AP



Arundhati and Jaismine joined the party. PTI & SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sured of 10 boxing medals.

Sachin was never really stretched. It was a cagey affair with both boxers adopting a cautious approach and reluctant to commit in attack.

For much of the bout, they waited for each other to make the first move so that they could create an

opening for a counter.

Sachin did just enough in every round, eventually securing a comfortable unanimous decision.

Ankush's duel with Mickey, too, was a tactical one, with neither willing to overcommit.

There were few close-range exchanges or sus-

tained body attacks as both preferred to be patient before launching attacks.

Ankush, however, looked the sharper of the two, displaying lightning-quick reflexes to slip and evade the 19-year-old's jabs before responding with crisp right-left combinations.

The Narender-Seko quarterfinal was easily the closest and most physical contest of the day.

The bout came alive after a caution-filled opening round as both of them traded punches with greater intent. Narender forced Seko into two standing counts — one each in the second and third rounds — which may have proved decisive in earning him a place in the semifinal.

Indian teams cruise to the threshold of glory

C'WEALTH TT

Amol Karhadkar
NEW DELHI

Diminutive Sreeja Akula and bespectacled Manav Thakkar produced contrasting yet equally influential performances as India's women and men marched into the team finals of the 22nd Commonwealth table tennis championships at the Thyagaraj Sports Complex on Wednesday.

Both teams outclassed England in their respective semifinals to set up title clashes against giant-killer Malaysia on Thursday. The afternoon session began with the Indian women taking centre stage before a vocal group of schoolchildren cheering the home side. Sreeja, blending her long-pimpled backhand with explosive forehand topspin winners, barely broke sweat in dispatching Cheuk Wong.

England responded through the experienced Tin-Tin Ho. Armed with her distinctive pen-hold grip and an uncanny ability to effectively use her backhand, Ho never allowed Yashaswini Ghorpade to settle into a rhythm and levelled the tie.

Teenager Syndrela Das restored India's advantage



Rising to the occasion: Sreeja came up with an inspired display once again to boost India. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

with another composed display before Sreeja returned for the decisive fourth rubber. Her duel with Ho turned out to be the contest of the tie, featuring engrossing rallies and relentless changes in momentum. Sreeja held her nerve, edging a gripping five-game battle to seal the place in the final.

Moments after the women exchanged handshakes, the men's teams walked onto the show court. While Manush Shah's opening rubber against Connor Green provided the early entertainment, it was Manav who earned widespread admiration.

Less than 24 hours after sustaining a deep cut to his forehead, against Australia, that required 13 stitches, Manav showed little sign of

discomfort. He produced another commanding display as India completed a 3-0 sweep without conceding a game. The victory sets up a mouth-watering rematch against Malaysia, with the Indian men eager to avenge the surprise defeat they suffered in the league stage.

The results (semifinals): Women: India bt England 3-1 (Sreeja Akula bt Cheuk Lam Jasin Wong 11-6, 11-3, 11-9; Yashaswini Ghorpade lost to Tin-Tin Ho 9-11, 6-11, 7-11; Syndrela Das bt Anna Green 11-7, 11-4, 11-9; Sreeja bt Ho 11-8, 5-11, 11-6, 8-11; 11-9). **Malaysia bt Australia 3-2.** **Men: India bt England 3-0** (Manush Shah bt Connor Green 11-9, 11-9, 11-6; Manav Thakkar bt Joseph Hunter 11-8, 11-4, 11-5; Harmeet Desai bt Benjamin Piggott 11-5, 11-5, 11-5). **Malaysia bt Singapore 3-1.**

‘Virtual magnet’ claims reveal why EVs need their rare-earths

A large amount of effort has gone towards replacing permanent magnets in the rotor with either electromagnets or just a piece of iron; however, efficiency, starting torque capability, and the maximum speed achievable are some important constraints that have kept such motors out of EVs

G. Bhuvaneswari

There have been a number of news reports recently about a startup in Bengaluru called Vimag Labs that has replaced rare-earth magnets in motors with so-called “virtual” magnets. One such report quoted Manish Seth, the start-up's CEO, as saying: “We remove permanent magnets, replace them with copper coils, and then through software, we generate magnetic fields inside the motor.” To understand this claim, it helps to first see how electric motors produce magnetic fields and why they use permanent magnets in the first place.

Rotor and stator
A motor needs a magnetic field to operate. One way to create it is using a permanent magnet. Another is to pass current through copper coils that have been wound around a ferromagnet, temporarily turning it into a magnet. This is called an electromagnet – and it is this approach that the startup has used, instead of permanent magnets. When an electrical machine converts electricity into mechanical motion, it is called a motor. On the other hand, a machine that converts mechanical movement into electricity is called a generator. In both cases, the conversion happens via a magnetic field. In a motor, for example, mechanical energy is harvested when the electric energy is used to rotate a component called the rotor. In a generator, electricity is harvested through conductors embedded in a stationary component called the stator. You can imagine both the stator and the rotor to be two concentric cylinders. Most of the time, the rotor is the inner cylinder. And the magnetic field is established in the gap between the stator and the rotor for the energy conversion process to happen.

An old technology
This is how the large generators in hydroelectric, thermal, and nuclear power plants work. And for a long time now, they have used electromagnets instead of permanent magnets. In these generators, a turbine spins the rotor. In a thermal or nuclear power station, the turbine is driven by steam. In a hydroelectric power station, it is driven by falling water. The rotor rotates at a fixed speed to generate an alternating current (AC) of frequency 50 Hz. The rotor has copper coils wound around its ferromagnetic core. When these coils are supplied with a direct current (DC), they create a magnetic field, and the core acquires a magnetic north and a magnetic south pole. And as the rotor spins, this magnetic field sweeps past the stator windings, inducing an alternating voltage in them. This helps convert mechanical power into electricity. This technology has been around for 135 years. The next question is how electricity can be fed continuously into coils that are themselves rotating. Enter: the brushless excitation system. The rotor coils need DC – but supplying it through sliding electrical contacts is difficult because the rotor is constantly spinning. The solution is to mount a rectifier, a device that



In any EV, the battery pack is the costliest and heaviest component, which is why the focus is on optimising the battery's rating. In turn, permanent magnet synchronous motors dominate the EV market because their efficiency is the highest at present. J. ALLEN EGENUSE
Real Creator IAS Edition <https://whatsapp.com/channel/0029Van2VRb6RGJOKH6oBd0F>

converts AC into DC, on the rotor itself. To this rotating rectifier, an AC is supplied from another generator. And this other generator is coupled to the same shaft of the turbine imparting mechanical power to the main generator.

Software and magnetism
This is essentially the principle behind the start-up's “virtual” magnet: software regulates the current flowing through the electromagnets, thus controlling the strength and direction of the magnetic field. The rectified current can be fed in a controlled manner to the copper coils in the rotor that would make the magnetic strength and direction controllable. In other words, the software is not creating magnetism by itself. It is just controlling how much current flows through the electromagnets, and thus how strong the magnetic field becomes. There is no novelty in this design. A permanent magnet establishes the magnetic field in the air gap of an electrical machine in a one-step process. And because the magnet already exists, no electrical energy is needed simply to create the magnetic field. On the other hand, with electromagnets, the magnetic field first has to be established, and the electric current modulated as per the requirement using software. And every additional step here consumes some energy. There are

magnetic losses in the ferromagnetic core, called core losses. The copper conductor has resistance losses. The electronic switches have switching and conduction losses. As a result, it is unlikely for a motor with an electromagnet to be more efficient than a motor with a permanent magnet.

Electromagnets in EVs
BMW and Renault have been trying to build such an electrically excited motor. The three-phase induction motor that Nikola Tesla invented in 1888 – a light yet rugged machine – was used by the first version of the Model S from Tesla in 2012. However, its efficiency was not good enough. Every 0.1% increase in efficiency of the propulsion motor drive matters in an electric vehicle (EV). This is because any increase in the drive's efficiency will improve the range drastically for a given battery rating. Put another way, for a given mileage, the battery size can be reduced when the efficiency of the motor drive improves. Thus, increasing the motor drive's efficiency will bring down the weight and cost of the car perceptibly. In any EV, the battery pack is the costliest and heaviest component, which is why the focus is on optimising the battery's rating. In turn, permanent magnet synchronous motors dominate the EV market because their efficiency is

the highest at present. Electromagnets are not the only alternative to permanent magnets. Another approach is the switched reluctance motor (SRM), whose rotor contains neither permanent magnets nor copper coils. Instead, SRMs have lower rotor inertia than even induction motors. In exchange, their torque comes in spurts, which makes the motor noisy and less efficient. Recently, Honda joined hands with a start-up from Canada called Enedym to improve the performance of an SRM to be used in an EV. Hitachi Astemo is similarly trying to use a synchronous reluctance motor in a battery-driven EV to get rid of the dependency on rare-earth magnets. On the whole, a large amount of effort has gone towards replacing permanent magnets in the rotor with either electromagnets or just a piece of iron. However, efficiency, starting torque capability, and the maximum speed achievable are some important constraints that have kept these motors out of EVs. At this time, we will have to wait and see how the Bengaluru start-up fares in the four-wheeler EV market. (G. Bhuvaneswari is professor, Electrical and Computer Engineering Department, Mahindra University, Hyderabad, and former faculty member, IIT-Delhi. bhuvan225@gmail.com)

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Vibranium’s equally unusual cousins

Vasudevan Mukunth

- QUESTION 1**
The radioactive debris from the destruction of planet X is called Y. Y taps the strength of the people of X and can even be lethal with prolonged exposure. Y is usually green in colour but it also comes in red, gold, and blue varieties, each with unusual effects. Name X and Y.
- QUESTION 2**
Name the synthetic alloy developed by the U.S. government and which is virtually indestructible once it has cooled into a specific shape. A covert weapons programme used this alloy to coat an individual human's skeleton and 'claws'. It also comes in a secondary form that's slightly weaker.
- QUESTION 3**
Mined in a once-great city in the Misty Mountains, _____ resembles silver in appearance, can't be tarnished, remarkably light, and tougher than steel.

- The city's smiths worked the material like cloth, producing mail shirts nearly weightless to wear but capable of stopping swinging blades. Fill in the blank.
- QUESTION 4**
Z is a room-temperature superconductor that levitates in the presence of magnetic fields — so metal-containing mountains on its world could float. Its immense commercial value on the earth drove the R.D.A. Corporation to colonise the world and mine it, seeding a great conflict between humans and the world's native dwellers. Name Z.
- QUESTION #5**
An alien crystalline substance, _____ spreads across landscapes and converts soil and structures as it does, in exchange releasing valuable minerals. Thus, it was an economic resource fuelling a global conflict as well as an ecological catastrophe, since it could also mutate exposed organisms. It was brought to the earth by a meteorite.



Visual: Name the substance shown here. In its universe, it is a critical component of warp drives. Planets containing this mineral were also at risk of tearing themselves apart due to the mineral's properties. AATREK/MEMORY-ALPHA

- Answers to July 28 quiz:**
1. 2006 Fields Medal winner for work along with Ben Green – **Ans: Terence Tao**
2. Showed there are infinite prime pairs within fixed distance of each other – **Ans: James Maynard**
3. 2006 laureate for proving the Poincaré conjecture – **Ans: Grigori Perelman**
4. Theory in which Alessio Figalli's work won a Fields Medal – **Ans: Optimal transport**
5. Adjective named for ancient Green inventor of algebra – **Ans: Diophantine**
Visual: **Maryna Viazovska**
- First contact:**
Tamal Biswas | K.N. Viswanathan | Sangeetha Varma | Snehil Jain | Pankaj Gharde



A Bengal tiger caught in a camera trap in the Bardia National Park, Nepal, in 2017, amid efforts to double the count of the big cats. AFP

Nepal’s tiger numbers climb 20% to estimated 429, says survey

Agence France-Presse

Nepal's tiger population has risen by roughly 20% in the past four years to an estimated 429, officials said on Wednesday, a conservation milestone despite challenges from human-wildlife conflict. The latest nationwide survey found tiger numbers had increased from 355 in 2022, reinforcing the Himalayan nation's reputation as a success story in big-cat conservation. “The data analysis shows that the tiger population has increased by five percent each year, and we are happy to see this increasing trend,” Bed Kumar Dhakal, spokesperson for Nepal's Department of National Parks and Wildlife Conservation, said. The survey was conducted between December and July, and was announced to coincide with International Tiger Day. It covered more than 7,300 square kilometres of Nepal's southern plains that are home to the predators.

Nepal pledged in 2010 to double its tiger numbers by 2022 and also became the first nation to meet that goal, boosting its tiger population to 355 in 2022 from about 121 in 2009

Wildlife officials deployed more than 3,600 motion-sensitive cameras across five protected areas, with experts analysing thousands of images to identify individual tigers by their distinctive stripe patterns. “The reason behind the increasing number of tigers is because we could keep their habitat secure,” said conservation department ecologist Hari Bhadra Acharya. Deforestation, habitat loss, and poaching have been major challenges for tiger populations across Asia, and Nepal has won international praise for reversing the decline. In 2010, Nepal joined 12 other countries in pledging to double tiger numbers by 2022. It became the first nation to meet that goal, boosting its tiger population to 355 in 2022 from about 121 in 2009.

Unintended risks
However, the conservation success has also brought unintended risks for communities living near tiger habitats. Government data shows at least 38 people were killed in tiger attacks between 2019 and 2023. “The local communities played a crucial role in increasing the tiger numbers, but the government and organisations are not taking action when the tigers are attacking the same communities,” said Nischal Neupane, an advocate for tiger victims in Bardiya district. The district is home to 112 tigers, up from only 18 in 2009. World Wide Fund for Nature Nepal representative Ghana Shyam Gurung said conservation gains must be matched by efforts to ensure “people and wildlife can thrive together”. “By investing in effective co-existence programmes, Nepal can continue to offer a powerful model for other tiger range countries.” More than 1,00,000 tigers roamed the wild at the start of the 20th century, but global numbers plunged to an estimated 3,200 in 2010 before recovering in parts of Asia through intensified conservation efforts.